

THE PERSISTENCE

Working Notes / Brain Dump / Style Bible

v0.3 — not for distribution — half-baked thoughts ahead

CORE CONCEPT — THE ELEVATOR PITCH

Memory isn't storage, it's **transport**. You don't remember your wedding day, you *go there*. Full sensory, full emotional, full phenomenological weight. The past isn't past—it's a place you can visit.

BUT: You still live forward. Time still moves. People still die. You just... never lose access to when they were alive.

The question isn't "what if we could remember everything perfectly"—it's "what happens to the *present* when the past is always available?"

tone & style notes

- **Quiet devastation** — not dystopia-loud, not utopia-bright. The technology is *normalized*. No one monologues about how amazing/terrible it is. It just *is*.
- **Melancholy without melodrama** — the sadness should creep, not announce itself. A woman laughing alone in a memorial hall. A man touching air where someone used to be.
- **Mundane future** — fax machines still exist. Coffee still gets cold. Eggs still burn. The tech is revolutionary but the *texture of life* remains recognizable.
- **Show the seams** — don't over-explain. Let readers feel confused the way a time-traveler would feel confused. Trust them.
- **Verb tense as weapon** — play with present/past tense to mirror the dual-presence experience. "She was there and is there and will always be there" etc.

What this is NOT:

- Not *Black Mirror* nihilism (technology bad! humans doomed!)
- Not techno-utopianism (we solved death! everything is fine!)
- Not a mystery/thriller about memory crimes (though those exist in-world)
- Not an action plot with blocking-weapons as MacGuffins

WORLDBUILDING CAVEATS — THINGS TO DECIDE

1. Is the tech biological, mechanical, or hybrid?

Current draft implies neural lacing + external storage. But is it:

- Implanted at birth? Opt-in surgery? Genetic modification?

- Universal or class-stratified? (draft says stratified but this has HUGE implications)
- Removable? What happens if the hardware fails?

→ LEAN INTO: the tech is so ubiquitous that its origins are fuzzy to most people. Like asking “who invented WiFi” — technically answerable but culturally irrelevant.

2. What about children?

If encoding starts at birth, do toddlers have accessible infant experiences? Is there a “first memory” anymore? What does childhood development look like when you can revisit your own tantrums?

→ DANGER ZONE: could get creepy fast. Maybe encoding requires neural maturity? First accessible memories around age 4-5?

3. Legal/consent implications

- Can your memories be subpoenaed?
- Can you delete experiences? Is deletion legal?
- What about witnesses to crimes—can they be *forced* to revisit?
- Divorce proceedings where both parties have perfect recall of every fight???

→ RICH TERRITORY but don’t let it dominate. This is literary fiction with SF elements, not legal thriller.

4. The “other people’s memories” problem

Draft mentions black market for accessing others’ experiences. But HOW? If the encoding is neural, how do you transfer?

Options:

- Direct neural link (intimate, requires trust/coercion)
- Extracted/copied files (implies your experiences are *data*)
- Some kind of broadcast/reception (public vs private experiences)

→ BE CAREFUL: this edges toward “uploading consciousness” territory which is a different story.

THEMATIC THREADS TO PULL

The Presence Problem

If you can always go back, why be here?

- Addiction framing—but addiction to *what*? Your own life?
- The present becomes a raw material factory for future visits
- “Experience hoarding” — living moments *for* the archive
- What does spontaneity mean when you know you’ll revisit?

Possible scene: Someone on a first date who keeps thinking “this will be a good one to revisit” and thereby ruins it by not being present. The memory they create is of not-being-present. Forever.

Grief Transformed (not eliminated)

You never lose access to the dead. But:

- They stop *generating* new moments
- The archive becomes finite, bounded, *complete*
- You can visit them forever but they can’t visit you
- Is it comfort or torture? (Answer: yes)

Possible scene: Someone realizes they’ve visited every moment with their dead spouse. There are no more surprises. The archive is a museum now, not a life.

Identity & Continuity

If you can perfectly revisit yourself at 20, are you the same person?

- The “younger self as stranger” phenomenon
 - Watching yourself make mistakes you can’t undo
 - Nostalgia for who you used to be vs. actually *being* who you used to be
 - Do people get “stuck” at certain ages? Refuse to update their self-concept?
- This is where it gets genuinely philosophical. Don’t answer, just explore.

The Blocking Threat

Loss of access = new form of death

- Not physical death, but experiential death
- Your past still exists but *you can’t get there*
- The terror isn’t of forgetting (passive) but of being *locked out* (active)
- Blocking as weapon, as punishment, as “treatment”

Note: The university plot is about well-intentioned blocking (addiction treatment) weaponized by true believers. The horror is that BOTH SIDES think they’re helping.

STRUCTURAL IDEAS

Option A: Braided Timelines

Multiple POV characters, each dealing with different aspects of the technology:

- Mara & Chen: Long-term relationship, navigating shared archives
- Kai: Someone who *resists* visiting, tries to live only in present

- Ezra & Yuki: Insiders who know what blocking really does
- Subject 7 (or equivalent): The human cost, shown not told

Risk: Could feel like interconnected short stories rather than novel. Needs strong throughline.

Option B: Single POV, Expanding Scope

One character (Mara?) whose personal story gradually reveals societal implications.

- Starts intimate: her relationship, her visits, her choices
- Expands: she becomes aware of blocking, of the crisis, of the stakes
- Climax: personal and political collide

More traditional but potentially more powerful. Readers experience the world through one lens.

Option C: The Document Novel

Excerpts, memos, transcripts, fragments. No single narrative.

- University memos
- Therapy session transcripts
- Legal depositions
- Personal journal entries (what does a journal look like when you can just revisit?)
- News articles, academic papers, advertising copy

High risk/high reward. Could be brilliant or unreadable. Requires very strong voice consistency across formats.

LANGUAGE & VOCABULARY

Words that are OBSOLETE:

- Forgot / forgotten / forget
- Reminisce (replaced by “visit” or “access”)
- Nostalgia (the emotion doesn’t exist)
- “Remember when...” (now just “when...”)
- Faded / hazy / dim (memories don’t degrade)
- Deja vu (you KNOW if you’ve been there before)

NEW vocabulary:

- **Visiting** — accessing a past experience
- **Weighted** / **weighting** — how much attention is on present vs. past
- **Drift** / **drifting** — unintentional visiting, losing present-focus

- **When** (as noun) — a specific temporal location (“which when?”)
- **Archive** — totality of one’s accessible experiences
- **Temporal coordinates** — specific timestamps for access
- **Blocking** — suppression of revisitation access
- **Now-sickness** — anxiety/depression related to present-focus
- **Presence** — being fully weighted in current moment (rare, notable)

Phrases to AVOID:

- “Back in my day” — still works but means something different
- “If only I could go back” — you CAN, that’s the point
- “I’ll never forget” — meaningless, nothing is forgotten
- “Time heals all wounds” — does it though? when you can reopen them infinitely?

QUESTIONS I DON’T HAVE ANSWERS TO YET

1. What do **dreams** look like in this world? Draft says they’re not captured, but people still dream—do dreams feel *different* now? More ephemeral because they’re the only ephemeral thing?
2. What about **learning**? If you can revisit a lecture infinitely, does education change? Do skills still require practice or can you just revisit the moment you did it right?
3. **Art and creativity** — is there still a market for fiction when everyone has infinite real experiences to access? Or does fiction become MORE valuable as the only source of novelty?
4. **Religion** — how do concepts of afterlife, karma, redemption change when your life is already preserved eternally? Do people visit their own deaths? (Can they?)
5. The **animals** question — do pets have persistence? Can you access a dog’s experience of you? (Probably not, but the desire would exist)
6. **Sex and intimacy** — obviously revisiting intimate moments is a thing, but what are the ethics? The etiquette? If you revisit sex with an ex, is that cheating? What if they’re dead?
7. **The singularity question** — if experiences can be stored and accessed, are they uploadable? Transferable? Is this a step toward digital consciousness or fundamentally different?

STUFF I’M STEALING FROM / INFLUENCED BY

- *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* — memory as relationship, loss as identity
- Borges, “Funes the Memorious” — the curse of perfect memory
- *Station Eleven* — quiet apocalypse, focus on human texture
- Ted Chiang generally — rigorous SF with emotional core

- *Never Let Me Go* — normalized horror, characters who don't question their world
- Tarkovsky's *Solaris* — memory as haunting, presence of the dead
- Anne Carson's *Nox* — grief as archive, fragment as form

IMMEDIATE NEXT STEPS

- ☐ Decide on structure (braided vs. single POV vs. documents)
- ☐ Write the blocking crisis from INSIDE — what does it feel like?
- ☐ Develop Kai's "presence resistance" — why does he refuse to visit?
- ☐ Figure out the ending — is this tragedy? Hope? Ambiguity?
- ☐ Research: actual neuroscience of memory reconsolidation (for plausibility)
- ☐ Write a scene that's JUST two people visiting the same moment together
- ☐ The memorial hall needs more — make it a full chapter?

"The past is never dead. It's not even past." — Faulkner
But what if he was being literal?